Methodology and Approach

CCTV Data Protection Impact Assessment | Work in progress

Project status

Work in progress. This is an independent educational portfolio project based on a fictional case. The published main DPIA currently covers the introductory sections up to and including the scope section. Detailed scoping is provided in a separate supporting document. The remaining DPIA stages have not yet been completed and will be added as the project develops.

Purpose and approach

My aim was to demonstrate how I approach a DPIA systematically: starting with research, choosing a practical method, applying it to a factual case, documenting uncertainty and preparing preliminary assessment material. This report explains what I did, why I did it and where AI supported my work. It is not a claim that a complete or validated DPIA has been performed.

01 Research before starting the assessment

I began by researching how a DPIA should be structured, which regulatory requirements and guidance were relevant, and what questions need to be answered to understand a processing operation. Rather than immediately completing template fields, I wanted a repeatable process that would help me identify the purpose, data flows, people involved, systems and boundaries of the assessment.

This research informed the practical scoping method described below. The method document is a synthesis of GDPR, EDPB/WP29 and CNIL-oriented guidance; it is a working method, not an official seven-step procedure issued by a single authority.

02 Selecting a practical scoping methodology

I used the following sequence from my practical methodology notes. It places understanding of the processing before analysis of necessity, proportionality and risk.

1. Establish purpose	Identify primary and secondary purposes; do not start with the software or equipment.
2. Map processing	Trace the personal-data lifecycle from collection and use through storage, potential disclosure and deletion.
3. Identify data and people	List data types, sources and categories of individuals who may be affected.
4. Map actors	Identify controller, processor, potential recipients and relevant internal functions.
5. Identify dependencies	Record relevant systems, technical functions and supporting assets.
6. Set boundaries	Distinguish in-scope, out-of-scope and unconfirmed activities, with reasons.

7. Validate scope	Identify questions for business, IT/security, privacy and suppliers; seek verification in a live engagement.

The first six steps guided my analysis of the case and the preparation of the separate scope document. Step seven remains pending: I have recorded validation questions but have not attempted to resolve them through fictional stakeholder answers.

03 Creating the fictional case

I asked ChatGPT to generate a fictional company scenario suitable for a DPIA exercise. The resulting case concerns Nordcenter ApS, a shopping-centre operator in Aarhus planning CCTV surveillance in selected common areas. I treated the case study as the factual input for the exercise, rather than adding unsubstantiated operational details to make the documentation appear complete.

The scenario describes 120 fixed cameras, approximately 80,000 visitors per week, local recording storage, restricted technical access by SecureVision ApS and a 14-day routine deletion period, with possible longer retention for specific incidents where permitted and necessary.

04 Applying the methodology to the case

I worked through the methodology step by step and sought answers in the case itself. I identified the security purposes; mapped capture, storage, conditional review, possible disclosure and deletion; identified affected individuals; mapped Nordcenter, SecureVision, relevant internal functions and potential recipients; and listed known technical dependencies.

I prepared my own working notes and draft responses to the questions raised by the method. I then used AI to review, challenge, revise and improve those drafts, including their clarity, organisation and internal consistency. This was an iterative drafting and review process, not a request for AI to independently produce the assessment without my input.

05 Recording unknowns rather than inventing answers

An important principle in my work was to distinguish case-supported facts from matters requiring confirmation. When the case did not answer a question, I documented it as outstanding in the DPIA material and/or supporting scope document instead of assuming that the issue had been resolved.

Examples include aspects of the technical implementation, potential integrations with other systems, the process for disclosure to police, responsibility for extended retention and whether independent retailers influence the purposes or essential means of processing. These are information gaps, not automatically confirmed compliance deficiencies.

06 Regulatory research and DPIA criteria

In parallel with the case analysis, I researched the GDPR provisions, DPIA triggers and CCTV-specific legal and regulatory guidance relevant to the scenario. I used AI as a secondary review tool to question and cross-check my identification of applicable criteria and legal issues.

A central trigger is GDPR Article 35(3)(c), concerning systematic monitoring of publicly accessible areas on a large scale. I considered the proposed camera coverage, continuous operation and number of visitors in explaining why a DPIA is required. Establishing the need for a DPIA does not establish the lawfulness or proportionality of the surveillance.

07 Preparing the preliminary DPIA documents

After the research and scoping work, I prepared the initial DPIA documentation, including the section referring to the separately documented scope. I used AI to review and revise the drafts for coherence, completeness against the available case information, consistency of terminology and presentation.

The main DPIA is deliberately published only through the scope section at this stage. I have not presented the later necessity and proportionality assessment, risk analysis, safeguards or final conclusions as completed work. These are intended future stages of the portfolio exercise.

08 Use of AI and author responsibility

AI was used for case generation, drafting support, critical feedback, consistency checking, editorial revision and review of researched legal issues. It was not treated as an authoritative legal source or as evidence that an unverified factual statement was correct.

I selected and applied the methodology, analysed the case, prepared working notes and draft answers, researched relevant requirements and decided how to document unresolved matters. I remain responsible for the published material and its limitations. Any references to AI checks mean supplementary review, not independent legal or stakeholder validation.

09 Validation deliberately deferred

I have not contacted any real organisation or simulated responses from Nordcenter staff, the processor or other stakeholders in order to close the outstanding questions. Instead, I have identified what would need to be confirmed and by whom. Formal validation has therefore not taken place, and the scope remains preliminary - pending validation.

A simulated consultation and validation exercise may be added later as a clearly labelled project stage. Until then, unresolved matters remain open; no fictional approvals or confirmations are implied.

10 Next stages

Future work may include structured validation of open questions, refinement of the scope where necessary, assessment of necessity and proportionality, identification and evaluation of risks to individuals, consideration of safeguards, residual-risk conclusions and an updated full DPIA. The project will be expanded incrementally, with the status of each document made clear.

Document set

01	**Methodology and Approach**	This explanation of the work and limitations
02	**Company Case**	Fictional facts used for the exercise
03	**DPIA**	Main document, currently published through scope
04	**DPIA Scope**	Detailed supporting scoping analysis

Reference basis

Project-specific facts: Nordcenter ApS - Company Case and the related DPIA / scope documents. Methodological basis: the accompanying Praktisk metode working notes (a synthesis drawing on GDPR, EDPB/WP29 and CNIL-oriented guidance). Legal references considered include GDPR Article 35, EDPB Guidelines 3/2019 on processing of personal data through video devices, and relevant Danish CCTV and data protection law.